

CANIS MAJOR

THE GREATER DOG

AN ANCIENT CONSTELLATION, CANIS MAJOR IS THE LARGER OF ORION'S TWO HUNTING DOGS. IT IS HOST TO SIRIUS, THE BRIGHTEST STAR IN THE ENTIRE NIGHT SKY.

Canis Major is near the heel of its master Orion, and close by (immediately north of Monoceros) is the smaller constellation Canis Minor. Canis Major represents Laelaps, a mythical dog so swift no prey could escape from it. The constellation is dominated by Sirius, which is actually a fairly average star of its type but outshines all other stars in the night sky because it is so close to us. The second-brightest star, Adhara, is a superluminous blue-white giant, which is much more distant but would outshine Sirius if placed next to it. Since the Milky Way crosses it, the constellation contains several notable deep-sky objects, including the clusters M41 and NGC 2362, both of which can be seen with the naked eye.

Sirius is the brightest star in the night sky. It is almost twice as bright as the next brightest, Canopus in the constellation Carina

